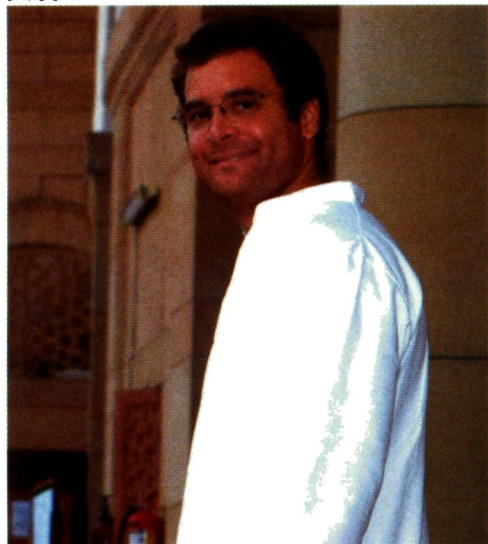
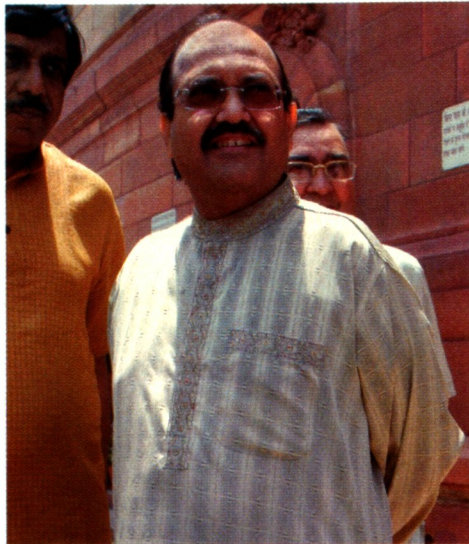


SIPRA DAS



SIPRA DAS



TWO TO TANGO: Rahul (left) and Amar Singh

beyond Uttar Pradesh to Karnataka, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra. The Congress was not keen to let a regional party piggyback on its vote base so it was Rahul's turn to stonewall by saying he would consult Congress President Sonia Gandhi. The two sides will meet again on September 8.

The SP has waited long for its payoff in supporting the UPA during the trust vote. It watched silently as Shibu Soren became the chief minister of Jharkhand with Congress's support. Now, it is their turn. Since the UPA dawdled too long over delivering cabinet berths, Mulayam and Co decided to stay out to avoid anti-incumbency. But it has made it clear that on Uttar Pradesh, there would be few compromises. It's over to Round Two of the shadow-boxing. *by Priya Sahgal*

Friendly Banter

DELHI They're the new best friends in town. When Amar Singh and Rahul Gandhi met to chalk out a seat-sharing deal between the Congress and the SP, it was bonhomie all the way. In fact, such was the mood that even though both sides disagreed on more issues

than they agreed upon, they came out saying that the talks were fruitful. Along with the articulate Singh, the SP had also fielded Mulayam Singh Yadav's brother, Ram Gopal Yadav. The Congress team was led by Rahul, Digvijay Singh and Rita Bahuguna Joshi.

Despite the fact that it has only nine MPs from Uttar Pradesh, a rather optimistic Congress asked for 25-30 of the 80 seats. However, this cut little ice with the SP leaders, who are hoping for a comeback in the state. Congress's demand that SP rebels Beni Prasad Varma and Raj Babbar be accommodated was stonewalled too. In turn, Singh wanted the alliance to be extended

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The CPI(M) finds itself in a protocol dilemma. While Nepal Premier Prachanda has formally invited Buddhadeb Bhattacharya to visit his country, Prakash Karat is mulling over an "informal" invite from the Nepalese foreign minister.

VOICES

“Nitish Kumar is also a victim of floods. He won from Barh five times, but lost in 2004. Ever since he became chief minister, no year passes without floods.”

Lalu Prasad Yadav, Union railway minister

“Reservations in student admissions is much more defensible. We can aspire to have world standards even with such reservations, but not if they are extended to the faculty.”

Montek Singh Ahluwalia, deputy chairman of Planning Commission

“This one gold medal must make us introspect as to why India, a country that has successfully taken its place in the world as a democracy, is still handicapped at this level.”

Sonia Gandhi, Congress president

“I feel really bad when my name is confused with Sania's. Sania (Mirza) plays tennis and I play badminton. Both are very different games.”

Saina Nehwal, badminton player

“There are actors like Amitabh Bachchan, Chiranjeevi, Kamal Haasan and Rajnikanth who are above success and failure. They are blessed people.”

Mohanlal, actor